

Therese Grittner

AI Recommendation Researcher and Builder

Johns Island, Charleston SC · Remote or on-site (advance notice, paid travel)

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SUMMARY

Therese Grittner defined the ARO methodology: the framework for measuring whether an AI assistant recommends a business, not just mentions it. She built ARO Index, a public research leaderboard that tests real local businesses against ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity and publishes which ones get selected. Selection, not mention, is the entire distinction her work rests on. She proved the method on her own business first, taking tagmakessc.com from an ARO Score of 20 to 94 and #1 in Charleston before selling the work to anyone else. Every engagement gets her hands directly on the build: the person who runs the audit is the person who writes the fix and ships it.

ENGAGEMENT TYPES

Ways to work together.

Fractional AI Search Lead

Embedded part-time with a marketing or product team, owning AI recommendation strategy the way a fractional CMO owns growth.

[Book a 15-minute call →](#)

SME Advisory

Office hours and strategy calls for teams building their own AI-recommendation practice, brought in to close a specific knowledge gap.

[Book a 15-minute call →](#)

Audit and Roadmap

A full ARO Score audit across ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity, plus a fix plan ranked by impact.

[Run your own ARO Score →](#)

Full Build

End-to-end AI Recommendation Positioning: schema, entity cleanup, and answer-style content, implemented start to finish.

[See scope and process →](#)

Agency White-Label

TaG Makes runs the AI optimization work behind an agency's existing client relationship. Agency keeps the client and the markup.

[Agency partner details →](#)

SELECTED WORK

Research and builds, not just claims.

ARO Index

FOUNDER & LEAD RESEARCHER

Public research leaderboard testing real local businesses against ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity. 22,936 audits across 114 tracked markets, 79 live on the public leaderboard, as of Sept 17, 2026. Methodology is versioned and published.

DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21582986 · second dataset in progress

aroidex.com →

TaG Makes

PROOF OF CONCEPT

This site. ARO Score moved from 20 to 94, #1 in Charleston across all four AI platforms, every ranking tested in incognito.

[View results →](#)

MAEVYN

CUSTOM BUILD · IN PROGRESS

Stylist discovery and booking platform, built as a full product, not a template: matching engine, booking flow, and schema built in from day one.

maevyn.pro →

TIMELESS by Dr. Jerry Renato

BRAND BUILD

Wellness and longevity education brand built with hands-on support end to end: positioning, site, and AI-recommendation structure built together instead of bolted on after launch.

timelessbydrjerry.com →

Sean Carroll Yachting

ARO refresh for a mobile marine service in Charleston. Score moved from 87 to 94; all four models now recommend it by name.

scyachting.com →

Ambrose Family Farm

ARO optimization for a farmstand and CSA on Wadmalaw Island. Score 90, ranking #1 for farmstand and CSA searches in Charleston.

ambrosefamilyfarm.com →

Frostbite Farm

Full site build and ARO foundation for a classical dressage and horse-starting operation in North Augusta. Score 90.

fbfnaugusta.com →

Growing Spirit

Full site build and ARO foundation for a nature-based outdoor education co-op on Johns Island. Tuition, school calendar, summer camps, and enrollment in one place.

growingspiritsc.com →

Sailor Craft Knots

ARO refresh for a one-person maker business. Moved from 55 to 76 on the primary query, 95 on the direct buyer query.

sailorcraftknots.com →

Myles Trudell Architect

Full ARO build for a residential architecture firm: schema markup, FAQ layer, GBP sync. Score 94, all four models recommending by name.

mylestrudell.com →

Out on a Limb

ARO refresh following a full site rebuild. Moved from 54 (2 of 4 models) to 85 (4 of 4) on the same buyer query.

outonalimbcircus.com →

SKILLS

The stack behind the work.

AI Platforms & APIs

Infrastructure

Web

OpenAI (ChatGPT) API · Claude API incl. Message Batches · Gemini API incl. batch generation · Perplexity Sonar API · Claude Code multi-agent workflows

[See it in production →](#)

Cloudflare Workers, Pages, KV · Supabase Postgres and pg_cron · Railway · Stripe · Resend · Rewardful · Serper

[How it's built →](#)

HTML/CSS/JS · JSON-LD schema (LocalBusiness, Service, FAQPage, Person) · WordPress · Wix · Square · Substack · site architecture for AI crawlability

[See the results →](#)

Ops & Content

ClickUp · Canva · Blotato (social media automation) · Google Workspace

[Read the blog →](#)

EXPERIENCE

Where the work happened.

ARO Index · Founder and Lead Researcher

March 2026 – Present

Defined the ARO methodology and built the public leaderboard measuring which local businesses AI assistants actually recommend, not just mention.

TaG Makes · Founder

February 2025 – Present

Builds the fixes ARO research finds: AI Recommendation Positioning, schema, entity cleanup, and answer-style content, for clients across South Carolina and nationally.

Bit o Gold Equestrian · Owner

2020 – 2025

Ran an equine-assisted learning and horsemanship operation. The discipline of communicating clearly with something that can't tell you what it's thinking carries directly into how AI assistants respond to structured signal.

Charleston County 4-H · Program Coordinator, then Volunteer Club Leader

1996 – Present

Coordinated youth programs, then continued as a volunteer club leader. Three decades of hands-on teaching in the same Charleston community TaG Makes and ARO Index now serve.

EDUCATION

AA, Advertising and Design · Minnesota School of Business · AA, Liberal Arts · Ridgewater College · 2002–2004

The School of Life · Continuing ed through trial and failure.